

SOIL HORIZONS

Our lifetimes are short compared to the thousands of years it can take for soil to form into layers, called horizons. Soil can stretch down for 50 m (164 ft).

Millipedes and other soil dwellers eat humus for its nutrients.



Humus

The top portion of soil is called humus. This dark horizon is made of dead things that have decayed (broken down).

Topsoil

You might have seen the mid-brown topsoil layer if you've planted seeds near the surface of soil. This mixture of dead matter, minerals, and small rock fragments is where most soil animals live.

Subsoil

A lot of digging would reveal this pale layer. Amongst tree roots, there are minerals and materials carried down by rainwater from above.

Mineral spotting

Beryl



Cassiterite



Pyrite



Turquoise



Schorl



Howlite

